

Polymyositis in Dogs

What is it?

Polymyositis is **inflammation of the muscles**, either in specific groups or throughout the body. It is believed to be an **immune system problem** in which the body attacks its own muscle. It is **not contagious**. It is more common in larger breeds and older dogs, but any dog can be affected.

Signs you might notice

- Stiff walking; short, tiptoe steps ("walking on eggshells")
- Tiring easily; exercise intolerance
- **Painful muscles** when touched
- Trouble swallowing, regurgitation or a change in bark
- Head held low or hunched posture
- Fever

Diagnosis

- Blood tests for muscle damage (CK enzyme) and infectious diseases
- X-rays or other imaging (including the esophagus)
- Electrical tests of muscles and nerves (EMG)
- **Muscle biopsy** — the most definitive test

Treatment

- **Corticosteroids** (such as prednisone) to calm inflammation and the immune response
- Start at a higher dose, then **reduce gradually** over months
- Other immunosuppressive drugs may be added
- **Physical therapy** helps maintain strength and function
- If swallowing is affected, feed upright and watch for regurgitation

What to expect

Most dogs improve within **days to weeks**. The outlook is generally good when treatment starts early; some muscle loss may remain. If treatment is delayed, recovery may be more limited.

Do not stop medication early or on your own — stopping too soon is a common reason for relapse.

Ongoing care

Regular rechecks with exams and blood tests let us track progress and adjust medication.

Call us right away if

Your dog has **difficulty breathing or swallowing**, coughs after eating, or becomes much weaker.